

Broke Boomers?!

FOR DECADES, WE have been told that the baby boomers—the generation that began nine months after American GIs returned home from World War Two—would be facing an insurmountable retirement crisis. Experts predicted the boomers would be broke in their old age.

Steven Malanga, a senior fellow at the conservative think tank Manhattan Institute, described the predictions:

By now, many retired baby boomers should be pinching pennies, at best, or battling destitution, at worst. For decades, the media and the experts they quoted warned that boomers weren't saving enough for a comfortable retirement. Thousands of stories expounded on the inadequacy of private-sector retirement plans and of the government policies regulating them. The bleak future for many boomers, one headline predicted, would be “Work, Work, Work and Die.”^{[35](#)}

How did those expert predictions turn out?

Retiring boomers are the richest generation in history. They hold over \$78 trillion in assets. *Fortune* magazine pointed out that during the Covid shutdowns, boomers as a group grew \$14 trillion richer.^{[36](#)} My colleague Ben Carlson dubbed them “The Luckiest Generation.”^{[37](#)}

Broke boomers is yet another forecast that was not merely wrong, but wildly so.



The forecasts about the retirement “crisis that wasn’t” were made decades ahead of time, difficult under even the best of circumstances. How do the pros do with shorter forecasts—mere months or years?

To answer that, allow me to introduce you to Lawrence Summers.

Universally regarded as a brilliant economist, Summers was President of Harvard University, Director of the National Economic Council under